

Ola Case Study: Increasing Ride Usage and Building Long-Term Ride Habits



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Introduction to Ola

Founded in 2010 by Bhavish Aggarwal and Ankit Bhati, headquartered in Bangalore. India's largest ride-hailing platform, operating in 250+ cities with 1.5M+ driver-partners. Services include cabs, auto-rickshaws, bikes, and electric vehicles.

Ola's Position

Ola is a key player in India's ride-hailing market, but its leadership position has shifted. While it offers a diverse fleet including auto-rickshaws and bikes, Uber now leads the cab segment with ~50% market share compared to Ola's ~34%. In electric two-wheelers, Ola Electric's share significantly dropped to ~18.44% by May 2025, overtaken by TVS Motor and Bajaj Auto. Ola's challenge is to maintain loyalty in this highly competitive and evolving mobility landscape.

Market Size

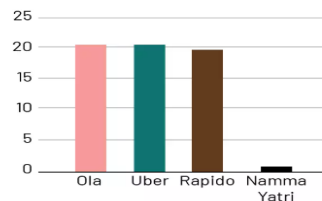
1. India's ride-hailing market valued at \$6.42B in 2023, projected to reach \$7.6B by 2028 (CAGR 6.3%).
2. Key competitors: Uber, Rapido. Ola holds ~60% market share.
3. Challenges: Price wars, driver retention, regulatory hurdles, and user churn due to inconsistent experiences.

Problem Statement

Our goal is to increase ride frequency on Ola. How can we strategically improve user retention through a focus on building consistent, long-term riding habits that embed Ola into users' regular travel patterns?

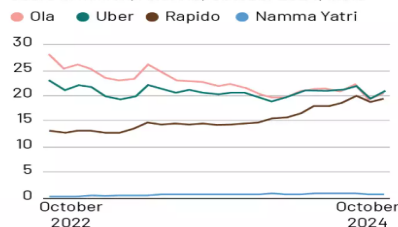
Ride booking

Monthly active users in million, Android, October 2024, India



Ride booking

Users in million, Android, October 2024, India



Overview Competitive Analysis User Persona User Journey Pain Points Problem Prioritization Solutions Metrics			
Feature / Metric			
Market Share	~59%	~41%	~8–10% (bike only)
Monthly Active Users (MAU)	~100M+	~93M	~30M
Geographic Reach	250+ cities (India only)	100+ cities (India)	100+ cities (Tier 2–3 focus)
Core Services	Cabs, Auto, EV, Rentals, Outstation	Cabs, Auto	Bike taxi, Auto
Price Competitiveness	 High (discounts)	 Competitive	 Cheapest (bike)
App Rating (Play Store)	 4.1	 4.3	 4.4
User Retention	 Moderate (low for casual users)	 Moderate	 Low (price-sensitive churn)
Unique Advantage	Wide service range, Ola EV, Ola Maps	Global network, brand trust	Ultra-low-cost, Tier 2–3 penetration



Power User – Priya, the Daily Commuter

Demographics: 28 years old, female, software engineer, lives in Bangalore.

Behavior: Uses Ola 4–5 times/week for office commutes and occasional evening outings. Prefers cabs for comfort and reliability.

Context: Relies on Ola to reach work on time (30 km round trip daily). Books rides during peak hours (8–10 AM, 6–8 PM).

Pain Points:

- Long wait times during peak hours (10–15 minutes).
- Frequent driver cancellations disrupt her schedule.
- Surge pricing increases commute costs unpredictably.

Jobs to Be Done:

- **Functional:** Get to work and back home quickly and reliably to maintain a consistent schedule.
- **Emotional:** Feel stress-free and confident that the ride will arrive on time, avoiding workplace tardiness.
- **Social:** Appear professional by arriving punctually for meetings and client interactions.

Motivations: Seeks predictable ETAs, affordable pricing, and a seamless booking experience to build trust in Ola for daily use.



Occasional User – Arjun, the College Student

Demographics: 21 years old, male, engineering student, lives in Delhi.

Behavior: Uses Ola 3–4 times/month for social outings (e.g., malls, movies) or travel to internships. Prefers auto-rickshaws or bike taxis for affordability.

Context: Books rides spontaneously, often in groups. Sensitive to pricing and compares Ola with Uber/Rapido.

Pain Points:

- Inconsistent pricing (e.g., surge pricing during weekends) discourages booking.
- Lack of loyalty rewards makes him switch to competitors offering discounts.
- Poor driver behavior (e.g., refusing short trips) frustrates him.

Jobs to Be Done:

- **Functional:** Travel to social or academic destinations affordably and conveniently.
- **Emotional:** Feel smart and in control by choosing the most cost-effective ride option.
- **Social:** Impress friends by organizing quick, hassle-free group travel.

Motivations: Values discounts, transparent pricing, and a fun, engaging app experience to encourage repeat usage.



Casual User – Sameer, the Business Traveler

Demographics: 35 years old, male, sales manager, based in Mumbai, travels frequently.

Behavior: Uses Ola 1–2 times/month, primarily for airport transfers or client meetings in other cities. Prefers premium cabs for comfort.

Context: Books rides in unfamiliar cities, often pre-scheduling for reliability. Prioritizes safety and professionalism.

Pain Points:

- Lack of trust in drivers (e.g., safety concerns in new cities).
- Inconsistent ride quality (e.g., unclean cars) impacts his professional image.
- Difficulty pre-scheduling rides with guaranteed availability.

Jobs to Be Done:

- **Functional:** Reach airports or client locations on time with minimal effort.
- **Emotional:** Feel safe and reassured, especially in unfamiliar locations or during late-night rides.
- **Social:** Project a polished, reliable image to clients by arriving in a clean, premium vehicle.

Motivations: Seeks safety features, high-quality rides, and easy scheduling to rely on Ola for critical trips.

Overview Competitive Analysis User Persona User Journey Pain Points Problem Prioritization Solutions Metrics					
User Journey Map: Booking a Ride in Ola App					
Phases	Initial Setup	Search & Select	Wait for Ride	Ride in Progress	Post-Ride Evaluation
Activity	Downloads Ola app, signs up. Enters pick-up location, selects ride type (e.g., cab, auto). Adds payment method (e.g., UPI, card).	Enters destination, reviews fare estimate. Compares ride options (e.g., AC, non-AC). Confirms booking.	Tracks driver ETA, receives driver details (name, car number). Waits at pick-up point.	Enjoys ride, tracks route on app. May request route change or assistance.	Rates driver, views ride summary. Receives receipt and loyalty points.
Thinking	"Is this app easy to use?"	"Is this fare reasonable?"	"How long will I wait?"	"Am I on the fastest route?"	"Was this a good experience?"
	"Will I get a ride quickly?"	"Which option suits my budget?"	"Is the driver reliable?"	"Is the driver safe?"	"Did I earn any rewards?"
	"Is my payment secure?"	"Will the driver accept?"	"What if they cancel?"	"Should I tip?"	"Will I use Ola again?"
Experience	🙄 Unsure/Curious	😊 Satisfied	😐 Neutral/Anxious	😄 Happy/Relieved	😊 Content/Loyal
Pain Points	Unfamiliar app interface. Payment method not accepted. Delay in location detection.	Inaccurate fare estimates. Limited ride options during peak hours. Booking confirmation delays.	Long wait times (10+ minutes). Driver cancellations. Poor communication from driver.	Route deviations or traffic delays. Uncomfortable ride conditions. Driver unresponsiveness.	Inconsistent rating system. No immediate feedback on loyalty points. Receipt errors.
Opportunity	Intuitive onboarding tutorial. Auto-detect location. Secure, one-tap payment setup.	Transparent fare breakdown. Wider ride variety with real-time availability. Instant booking confirmation.	Real-time ETA updates. Driver cancellation penalties. In-app chat with driver.	Optimized routes with traffic data. In-ride comfort options (e.g., AC toggle). 24/7 support chat.	Simplified rating with quick feedback. Instant loyalty point visibility. Error-free receipts.

Drop-off Moments (Pain Points) and Opportunities for Improvement

Drop-off Moment 1: High Fare / Surge Pricing & Price Comparison

Pain Point: Unexpectedly high fare (surge or regular) leads to booking abandonment or switching to competitors after price comparison.

Opportunity:

- **Transparent Surge Communication:** Clearly explain surge reasons and duration.
- **"Fare Drop Alert":** Notify users when surge decreases or suggest cheaper later booking times.
- **Multi-modal Suggestions:** Offer cost-effective alternatives like public transport + last-mile options within the app.
- **Pre-booked/Scheduled Ride Discounts:** Incentivize advance booking with fixed, lower fares.
- **Ola Value Proposition:** Highlight reliability, safety, and vehicle options to justify the fare.

Drop-off Moment 2: Long Wait Times / No Drivers Available

Pain Point: After confirming, users see "No drivers available" or excessively long estimated wait times (e.g., 15+ minutes), leading to frustration and switching apps.

Opportunity:

- **Real-time Driver Density Map:** Show nearby drivers on the map before booking to manage expectations.
- **Proactive Demand Management:** Use AI to anticipate demand and encourage drivers to move to high-demand areas.
- **Pre-booking with Guaranteed Assignment:** Offer a premium service with guaranteed driver assignment for pre-scheduled rides.
- **"Pool/Shared Ride" Prompt:** Proactively suggest shared rides as a quicker alternative if solo rides are scarce.

Drop-off Moment 3: Driver Cancellations

Pain Point: Assigned drivers frequently cancel, wasting user time and leading to frustration and churn, often due to low driver incentives.

Opportunity:

- **Predictive Cancellation Flagging:** Use AI to prioritize matching with reliable drivers.
- **Auto-Reassignment:** Automatically find a new driver if one cancels, without user re-booking.
- **Improved Driver Incentives:** Ensure Ola's platform is lucrative and fair for drivers.
- **Driver Accountability:** Implement stronger disincentives for arbitrary cancellations.

Drop-off Moment 4: Dissatisfied In-Ride Experiences

Pain Point: Issues during the ride like longer routes, unsafe driving, rude behavior, unclean vehicles, or non-functional AC, degrade trust and satisfaction, reducing future Ola usage.

Opportunity:

- **In-App Reporting During Ride:** Allow users to report mid-ride issues for immediate support.
- **Enhanced Driver Training & Compliance:** Regular training on customer service, route adherence, maintenance, and hygiene.
- **AI-Powered Route Adherence:** System automatically flags significant route deviations and alerts driver/support.
- **Driver Profiles with Badges:** Highlight drivers with high ratings, good service records, or "Clean Car" badges.

Drop-off Moment 5: Post-Ride Issues / Payment Hassle

Pain Point: Payment failures, unclear fare breakdowns, dispute resolution difficulties, or complicated feedback processes leave a negative last impression.

Opportunity:

- **Simplified Dispute Resolution:** Easy in-app flow for reporting payment or ride issues.
- **Transparent Fare Breakdown:** Clearly itemize all fare components before and after the ride.
- **Subscription Benefits:** Promote subscription models like "Ola Monthly Pass" for simplified payments and value.
- **Gamified Feedback:** Encourage rating with quick taps and optional comments, rewarding constructive feedback.

Overview Competitive Analysis User Persona User Journey Pain Points Problem Prioritization Solutions Metrics				
Pain Point	Problem Level	Intensity (1-5)	Feasibility (1-5)	Priority
Post-Ride Payment/Disputes	High	5	4	P1
High Surge Pricing / Price Comparison	High	5	3	P2
Long Wait Times/No Drivers Available	Medium	4	3	P3
Low Driver Incentives / Drivers Choosing Other Platforms	Medium	4	2	P4
Dissatisfied In-Ride Experiences (Rude, Unhygienic)	Low	3	3	P6
Driver Cancellation	Low	4	2	P5

Solution 1: Ola Ride Streak Rewards (Addresses Habit Building, Retention)

What is it?

A gamified loyalty program that rewards users for consecutive days/weeks of taking rides. Example: "Complete 3 rides in 3 days, get 50% off your 4th ride" or "Maintain a weekly streak for bonus points/discounts."

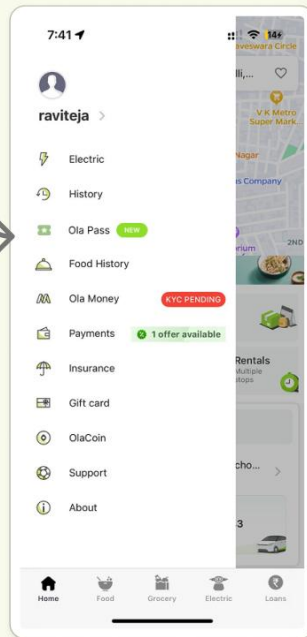
Why it works?

Directly encourages consistent usage, builds routine, and adds a fun, rewarding element to ride-hailing. Low psychological cost for users to participate.

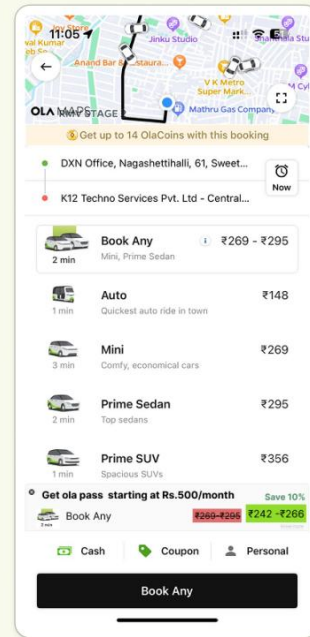
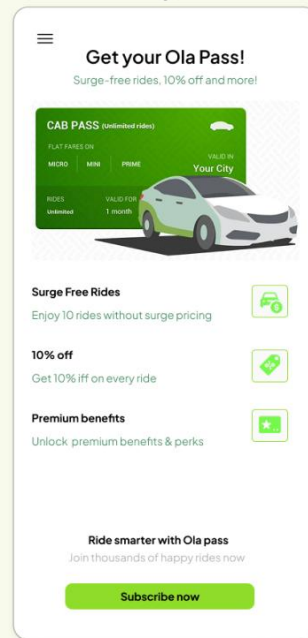
Primary Problem Addressed

Increasing ride usage, building long-term ride habits.

Ola pass in main menu



Ola pass working & benefits to users



Ola pass popup to make user aware of benefits during booking

Solution 2: Ola Monthly Pass (Addresses Cost, Retention, Habit)

What is it?

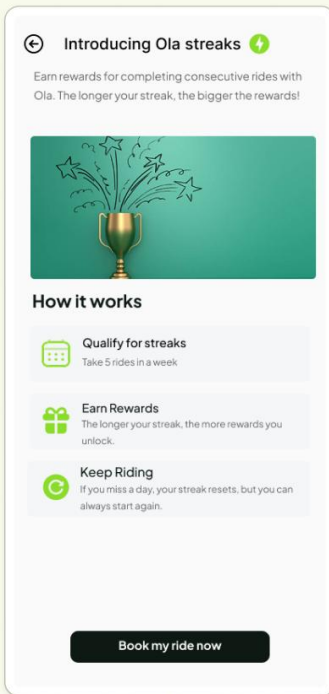
A subscription service (e.g., monthly/quarterly) offering benefits like a fixed number of surge-free rides, discounted rides, priority booking, premium support, and specifically a 10% discount on all rides. This directly tackles the user's desire for consistent affordability.

Why it works?

Locks in users, increases their lifetime value, and incentivizes more frequent usage to maximize subscription value. Creates a sense of belonging and exclusivity.

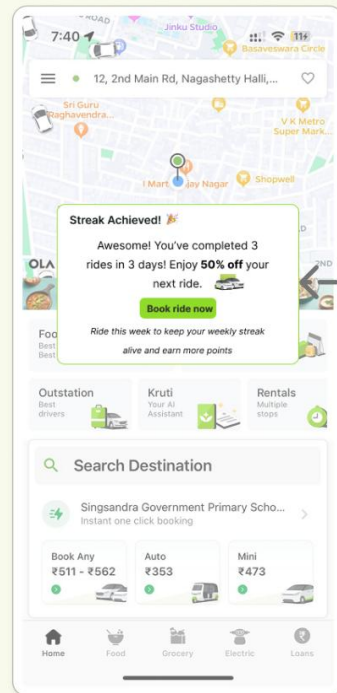
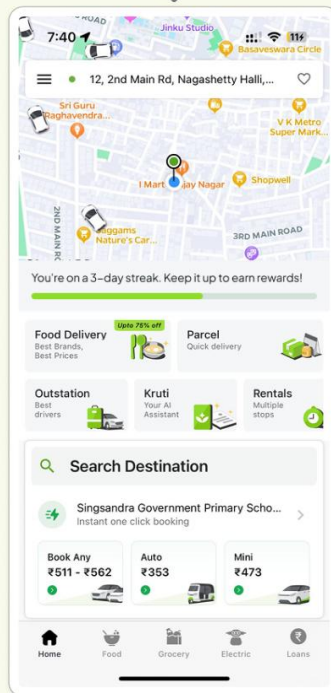
Primary Problem Addressed

User retention, building long-term habits (by making Ola the default choice) and directly addressing pricing concerns.



Info page on how Ola streaks function for the user

A streak progress bar for rewards to encourage users to book more rides.



Reward popup for streak completion, motivating more rides.

Solution 3: Smart Surge Predictor (Addresses High Surge, Price Comparison, Retention)

What is it?

When surge pricing is active, the app displays:

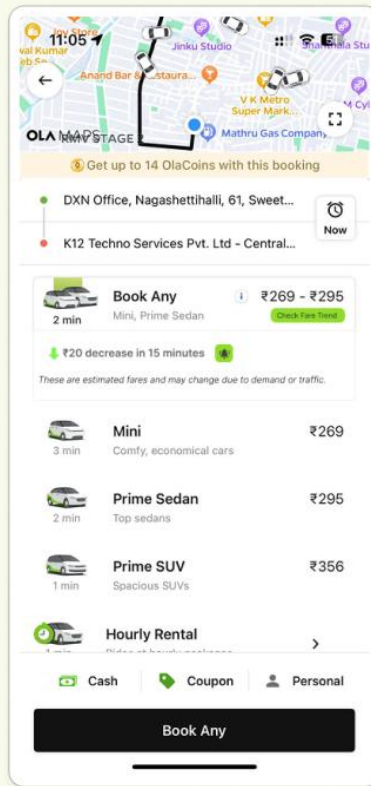
- An estimated time when the surge might decrease/increase.
- A clear "Notify me when fare drops" button.
- Alternative ride options (e.g., cheaper Ola Auto/Bike options, if available), explicitly showing price differences.
- Optionally, integration with public transport data for multi-modal suggestions.

Why it works?

Reduces user frustration and perceived unfairness of surge, provides options, and keeps users within the Ola ecosystem even if they don't book immediately. Addresses direct competitive price comparison.

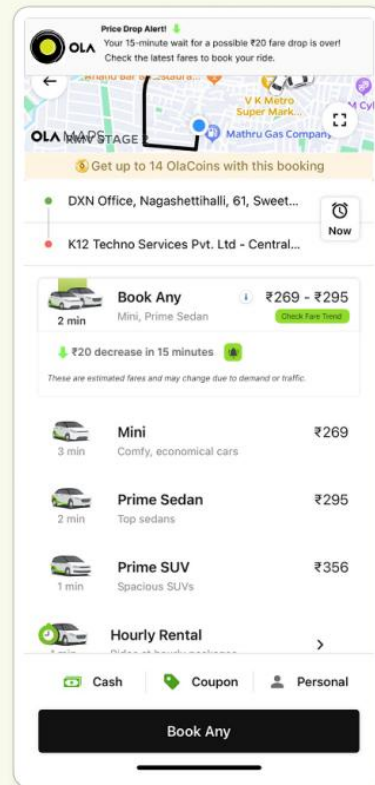
Primary Problem Addressed

Mitigating high surge pricing, preventing immediate drop-off.



Smart price predictor for time-based price shifts, a notification button for price drop alerts.

In-app notification for users when prices drop.



Solution 4 : Automated Driver Re-Match & Small Discount (Addresses Driver Cancellations, Retention)

What is it?

If a driver cancels, the system immediately tries to re-match the user with a new driver in the background. If a re-match happens within X seconds/minutes, the user is notified, and potentially offered a small, temporary discount on that ride as an apology for the inconvenience.

Why it works?

Minimizes user effort and frustration from cancellations, demonstrates Ola's commitment to service recovery, and encourages continuing with Ola.

Primary Problem Addressed

Reducing driver cancellations, improving reliability.

Solution 5 : Enhanced Driver Quality & Hygiene Program (Addresses In-Ride Experience)

What is it?

Implement mandatory training on customer service and vehicle hygiene, allow discreet in-app reporting of mid-ride issues, and conduct regular vehicle spot checks. Reward high-quality drivers with visible badges.

Why it works?

Directly addresses critical aspects of the in-ride experience that impact trust and repeat usage, leading to a more pleasant journey for users.

Primary Problem Addressed

Dissatisfied experiences with drivers (rude behavior, unhygienic cabs).

Overview	Competitive Analysis	User Persona	User Journey	Pain Points	Problem Prioritization	Solutions	Metrics
Solution	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Score (Reach × Impact × Confidence) / Effort	Priority	
Ola Ride Streak Rewards	8	8	7	4	112	P2 	
Ola Monthly Pass	9	9	8	4	162	P1 	
Smart Surge Predictor & Alternative	7	7	7	5	68.6	P3	
Automated Driver Re-Match & Small Discount	6	6	6	6	36	P5	
Enhanced Driver Quality & Hygiene Program	6	8	6	5	57.6	P4	

Ola Monthly Pass

Drives:

- **User Frequency**
- **User Retention**
- **Price Perceived Value**

Supporting Metrics:

- Monthly active pass subscribers
- Avg. rides/user among pass holders
- Pass renewal rate
- CAC vs LTV for pass users

Ola Ride Streak Rewards

Drives:

- **User Frequency**
- **User Retention**

Supporting Metrics:

- % of users with active streaks
- Avg. ride interval reduction
- Reward redemption rate
- Weekly active user growth

Smart Surge Predictor

Drives:

- **Ride Conversion Rate**
- **Price Perceived Value**

Supporting Metrics:

- Surge drop-off rate
- Click-through rate
- Ride conversion after prediction
- User satisfaction post-surge ride

Ola's North Star Metric: **Total Rides per User per Month**



THANK YOU

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